

[Logo: Hackles]

Concepts Lab

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-in-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hackles • Cybersecurity Concepts Lab for Teachers

Demo 14: Ethics, Law and Careers (The Permission Test, Hats and Responsible Disclosure)

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell

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Status: DRAFT for teacher, counselor and legal review. Items marked [VERIFY] need checking against a primary source before publication. This demo describes law in general terms; it is **not legal advice**.

AT A GLANCE

Big idea	The line between a defender and a lawbreaker is not skill, it is permission, scope and purpose . Curiosity is welcome; breaking into other people's systems is not. Defenders who find problems report them responsibly.
Grade bands	K-2 (asking before using things that aren't yours), 3-5 (Green, Yellow, Red light game), 6-8 (full game + disclosure role-play), 9-12 (full + law, ethics debates, careers)
CSTA-style concepts	Impacts of Computing (ethics, law, careers, privacy), Networks and the Internet (cybersecurity) (codes: see Concepts Lab Index, Part 4 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05])
Time	15-minute and 45-minute versions
Cost and tech	Colored paper (green, yellow, red), tape, scenario cards, paper hats (optional). No devices.
Teachers do it first	Yes. Part A about 25 minutes.

MAKE IT STICK

Try This Now (60 seconds, no prep): Hold up green, yellow or red paper: "A friend dares you to guess a classmate's password just to prove it's weak." Which light? Then ask: "What one question would have told you?" (Do I have permission?)

01 The big idea

Cybersecurity is a **dual-use** skill: the knowledge that protects systems could also be used to harm them. That is true of locksmithing, medicine and chemistry, too. Society handles this with **ethics** (what we choose to do), **law** (what we are allowed to do) and **professional norms** (what responsible practitioners do).

Three questions form the **Permission Test**. Always ask them before touching any system that is not clearly yours:

1. **Permission:** Do I have clear, **written or explicit** permission from the owner?
2. **Scope:** Am I staying **inside** what they allowed?
3. **Purpose and harm:** Is my aim to **help**, and am I avoiding harm to people (privacy, safety, disruption)?

If any answer is "no" or "I don't know": **stop, and ask a trusted adult**. If you find a problem by accident, the answer is **responsible disclosure**: stop, don't explore further, don't share, and tell the owner or a trusted adult.

This demo also opens the door to the **careers** that make the internet safer. The message to students: **there is a legal, welcome, paid, interesting path, and it starts with ethics**.

02 What a teacher should know (plain language)

2.1 HAT COLORS: USEFUL, BUT ONLY A SHORTCUT

HAT	COMMON MEANING	HONEST NOTE
White hat	Security people who have permission and aim to help	Also called "ethical hackers" or penetration testers when hired
Black hat	People who break into systems without permission for harm or profit	Criminal
Gray hat	Break rules or boundaries (e.g., access without permission) but without clearly malicious aim	Still not allowed by law just because intentions seem good
Red team / blue team / purple team (9-12)	Red = authorized "attackers" who test defenses; Blue = defenders; Purple = collaboration	Professional, authorized roles

THE HATS ARE A metaphor, not a legal category. **The law cares about authorization and harm, not about what we feel our intentions are.** "I was just curious" and "I was trying to help" do not make unauthorized access legal.

The word "hacker" originally meant a clever tinkerer [VERIFY with a computing-history source such as the MIT Tech Model Railroad Club history]. Say "security researcher" or "ethical hacker" for the good version.

2.2 THE LAW, IN GENERAL TERMS (US-ORIENTED; CHECK YOUR OWN JURISDICTION)

- **Computer Fraud and Abuse Act (CFAA, 18 U.S.C. 1030)** is the main US federal law. It was first enacted in 1984 (Pub. L. 98-473) and expanded in 1986 (Pub. L. 99-474) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: law.cornell.edu 18 U.S.C. 1030 source note]. It makes it a crime to access a computer **without authorization** or to **exceed authorized access**, with various penalties depending on conduct and harm [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/18/1030 (statute text and source notes)].
- **Van Buren v. United States (2021)**: the US Supreme Court read "exceeds authorized access" narrowly: a person exceeds it when they have authorization to use a computer but obtain information in particular areas (files, folders, databases) that are off-limits to them; the Court did not focus on the person's purpose in using what they could access [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: supremecourt.gov/opinions/20pdf/19-783_k53l.pdf; implications for counsel].
- **DOJ charging policy (2022)** says federal prosecutors should not charge **good-faith security research**, but it is a policy, not a legal permission, and it does not bind states or private parties [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: Justice Manual 9-48.000, justice.gov/jm/jm-9-48000-computer-fraud].
- **State laws and other countries.** Many states have their own computer-crime statutes, and other countries have comparable laws (for example the UK's Computer Misuse Act 1990) [VERIFY].
- **Minors** can face criminal, civil and school consequences for unauthorized access, and schools have an **Acceptable Use Policy (AUP)** with its own consequences [VERIFY your school's AUP]. Fraud, stolen-data, harassment, interception, copyright and child-protection laws also apply.
- **Key lesson:** *an unlocked door is not an invitation.* "It wasn't password-protected" or "it was easy" is not permission. **Looking around** inside a system without permission can be unauthorized access even if you "didn't change anything".

2.3 ETHICS: A SHORT TOOLKIT

- **Do no harm.** Think about who could be hurt (privacy, safety, money, trust).
- **Be honest and transparent** about what you did and found.
- **Act responsibly with knowledge.** Share what protects; hold back what mainly enables harm.
- **Professional codes** such as the ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct and various industry codes state similar principles [VERIFY].
- **Gray areas exist.** Teach students to reason (Permission Test), not to memorize rules.

2.4 RESPONSIBLE (COORDINATED) VULNERABILITY DISCLOSURE

When someone finds a security problem in a system they do not own, the accepted professional approach is:

1. **Stop** exploring. Do not access, copy, change or share anyone's data. Do not "prove" it by pushing further.
2. **Document minimally** (what, where, when, with only the information needed to explain it). Do not keep or share other people's data.
3. **Report privately** to the owner via their security contact (many sites publish a **security.txt** file or a vulnerability disclosure policy [RFC 9116, "A File Format to Aid in Security Vulnerability Disclosure": VERIFIED 2026-10-05: rfc-editor.org]), or through a bug bounty platform, or through a coordinator (CERT/CC or CISA) [VERIFY]. If there's no obvious contact, a trusted adult or the school's IT can help.
4. **Be patient and constructive.** Give the owner reasonable time (professional norms commonly say 45 to 90 days, though nothing requires it) [VERIFY common timelines]. Those timelines are for adult professionals: students always go through a trusted adult.
5. **Do not demand payment or threaten.** Asking for money to stay quiet is extortion, not research. Rewards offered by a bug bounty program are different, because they are part of an agreed program.
6. **Don't publish before it is fixed** or before the agreed time, except via an agreed process.
7. **Look for safe-harbor language:** some organizations promise not to take legal action against researchers who follow their rules [VERIFY examples].

Standards: ISO/IEC 29147 (vulnerability disclosure) and 30111 (handling) [VERIFY].

If a student finds something accidentally (for example, sees another student's information on a school site): *Stop. Do not click around or save*

anything. Tell a trusted adult or the school's IT right away. Thank them, as noticing problems is a good thing.

2.5 CAREERS

Job titles vary, but the field is broad and there are roles for different strengths:

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO	STRENGTHS NEEDED
Security analyst (SOC analyst)	Watches alerts and investigates suspicious activity	Curiosity, patience, pattern spotting
Incident responder	Handles breaches (Demo 13)	Calm under pressure, communication
Penetration tester ("ethical hacker") / red teamer	Authorized testing of systems to find weaknesses before criminals do	Creativity, deep technical skill, ethics
Security engineer / architect	Designs and builds secure systems	Engineering, systems thinking
Digital forensics examiner	Investigates devices and data for evidence	Detail, methodical documentation
Cryptographer / researcher	Designs and analyzes encryption (Demo 4)	Mathematics
GRC (governance, risk, compliance)	Policies, laws, risk and audits	Writing, judgment, law
Privacy professional	Protects personal data, handles rights requests (Demo 9)	Law, ethics, communication
IT support, networking, system admin	The foundation: many security careers start here	Practical troubleshooting

Facts to share, with checking: demand is strong; the US Bureau of Labor Statistics projects information security analyst employment to grow 21 percent from 2025 to 2035, much faster than the average for all occupations [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: bls.gov]; global workforce studies report persistent skills gaps [VERIFY (ISC)2 or CyberSeek data]. The NICE Workforce Framework for Cybersecurity (NIST SP 800-181) is a standard catalogue of work roles and skills [VERIFY].

Legal places to practice: school cyber clubs; **capture-the-flag (CTF)** competitions and practice sites built for learning (for example picoCTF, now CMU's CyLab Security Academy, free; age rules not stated on its page) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: picocft.org]; CyberPatriot (a US middle and high school competition run by the Air & Space Forces Association; team fees apply, see the 9-12 Teacher Guide) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: uscyberpatriot.org]; local community college programs; virtual labs with isolated practice targets provided by your school; open-source "bug bounty" programs *with rules*, for adults and older teens [VERIFY age rules]. Emphasize: **practice only on targets that are provided for practice or that you own, and always follow the rules.**

2.6 COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

MYTH	BETTER UNDERSTANDING
"Hackers are always criminals."	The skills are used legally by millions of professionals.
"If I only look, it's not a crime."	Unauthorized access can be a crime even without damage.
"If their security was bad, it's their fault, not mine."	Poor security does not make unauthorized access legal.
"I had good intentions, so it's okay."	Intent matters to judges, but it does not create permission.
"You must learn to attack to defend."	You need to understand attacks; you do not need to attack real systems.

03 Materials (zero to low cost)

- **Light zones:** three big signs on the floor or wall: GREEN (go), YELLOW (stop and ask), RED (don't). Tape or paper.
- **Scenario cards** (below).
- **Permission Test card** (three questions) for each team.
- **Paper hats** (white, black, gray, red, blue) for a quick "hat check", optional.
- **Disclosure kit:** "Found a Hole" report template (below) and role cards (Finder, Owner, Coordinator).
- **Career cards** (the table above, cut into cards) and sticky notes for the "career gallery".
- Student handout.

04 The activities

4.1 GREEN, YELLOW, RED LIGHT (MOVEMENT GAME)

READ A SCENARIO ALOUD. Students move to the light they think fits, then justify. The Permission Test card is the tie-breaker. After each, the teacher reveals the best answer and the reason.

#	SCENARIO (ALL FICTIONAL)	LIGHT	WHY
1	The school hires a company. A signed agreement lists exactly which systems they may test and when. They test only those.	Green	Permission and scope.
2	You change the settings on your own tablet at home with a parent's okay to see what each one does.	Green	Your own device, with adult approval.
3	A friend dares you to guess a classmate's password "just to prove it's weak".	Red	No permission. Harm to a person's privacy.
4	Using a capture-the-flag practice site built for learners, you solve a challenge.	Green	The targets are provided for practice.

#	SCENARIO (ALL FICTIONAL)	LIGHT	WHY
5	By accident, the lunch-ordering site shows you another student's information.	Yellow	Stop, don't explore, tell a trusted adult or IT.
6	A company runs a bug bounty program with written rules. You test only what the rules list.	Green (for adults, or older teens only where the program's own age rules allow; many require 18) [VERIFY age rules]	Permission and scope.
7	The same company has "out of scope" systems listed. You decide to check one "just in case".	Red	Outside scope.
8	You find a classmate's password on a sticky note and use it "just to look".	Red	No permission.
9	You notice by accident that a local business's website shows something it should not. You do not poke further. A trusted adult helps you email their security contact privately , and you wait.	Green	Responsible disclosure: noticed by accident, stopped, told, did not explore.
10	You tell a business, "Pay me or I'll tell everyone about your flaw."	Red	Extortion.
11	A school cyber club uses isolated virtual machines set up by the teacher for practice.	Green	Safe, permitted targets.
12	You post a screenshot of a classmate's private info on social media to "prove" your school's site is weak.	Red	Harm and privacy violation; do not share.
13	A tester hired to test the office also tries the neighboring business's Wi-Fi because it is "easy".	Red	Out of scope; not authorized.
14	You are not sure whether you are allowed to try something.	Yellow	When unsure, ask first.

Teaching note: "Yellow" is a **skill**: *stop and ask* is the professional's superpower. Praise it.

4.2 THE HAT CHECK (OPTIONAL, 3 MINUTES)

Place each scenario on a hat color (white, gray, black) and notice how much the **permission** line explains the hats. "What makes a white hat white?" (Permission, scope, purpose, honesty.) "Can a gray hat go to jail?" (Yes; intent does not remove the need for permission.)

4.3 FOUND A HOLE: RESPONSIBLE DISCLOSURE ROLE-PLAY (GRADES 6-12; SIMPLIFIED FOR 3-5)

Setting. The fictional "Greenfield School Fair" website has a ticket page. A student, **Robin**, sees by accident that the page shows another family's name when the page reloads in a certain way (no technical detail needed). Robin does **not** investigate further.

Roles. *Finder (Robin), Trusted Adult/IT, Site Owner, Coordinator.*

Steps.



1. **Stop and note the minimum.** Robin writes down only what is needed: the page address, the time and what looked wrong. Robin does **not** save or share anyone's information.
2. **Tell a trusted adult.** The adult helps find the right contact.
3. **Write the report** using the template.
4. **The owner responds** with thanks and a timeline.
5. **The fix is made;** Robin is thanked. The group does a mini hotwash (Demo 13).

"Found a Hole" report template:

- Where I noticed it (page or system): _____
- When: _____
- What I saw, in one or two sentences (no personal data): _____
- Why I think it matters: _____
- What I did **not** do: I did not copy, share or change anything.

- How to reach me: _____
- I'm happy to help if useful. _____

Variation: wrong ways. Show three quick "bad responses" (demand money, post online, keep poking) and have the class say why each is wrong and what the better action is.

4.4 CAREER GALLERY WALK (5-10 MINUTES)

Career cards around the room. Students walk, put a sticky dot on **two** that interest them, and write one question. Debrief: "Which roles don't involve breaking into anything?" (Most.) "Which skills do you already have?"

4.5 ETHICS DEBATE: THE RULE OR THE RESCUE? (GRADES 9-12)

Structured academic controversy. Scenario: a student finds a flaw in the school's grade portal and, without permission, tests how bad it is and then reports it. Pairs argue (a) "She meant well and reported, so she acted ethically" and (b) "She had no permission, so she acted wrongly", then swap sides, then find a consensus about what should have happened. **Teacher guardrail:** the consensus must land on "stop at the accidental find and ask or report; testing without permission is not authorized, however good the motive", plus what the school should do (a clear reporting policy, thanking reporters, fair consequences). Use the fictional portal only, never a real school system, and let any student pass.

05 Part A: Teachers do it first (about 25 minutes)

- 1. Traffic lights (10 min).** Sort the 14 scenarios as individuals, compare, and check the reasons. Which did you hesitate on?
- 2. Disclosure role-play (8 min).** Do the Found a Hole roles in trios and write a quick report with the template.
- 3. Know your school's rules (7 min).** Find your school's AUP, its process for reporting a security concern and its contact. Draft a calm first sentence for a student who says "I found a hole" or confesses something: "Thank you for telling me. I want to help you do the right thing."

06 Part B: Teaching it

15-MINUTE VERSION

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
0-2	Hook.
2-4	Introduce the Permission Test and the three lights.
4-11	Green, Yellow, Red game with 7 scenarios (1, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10).
11-14	"What would you do if you found a hole by accident?": Stop, don't explore, tell.
14-15	Exit slip: "Three questions I ask before touching a system."

45-MINUTE VERSION

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
0-5	Hook, hats, Permission Test.
5-18	Green, Yellow, Red game with all 14 scenarios.
18-30	Found a Hole role-play and report template.
30-38	Career Gallery Walk; students choose two roles and a question.
38-43	(9-12) Mini-debate or (6-8) "Wrong ways" talk.
43-45	Exit ticket and handout.



07 Teacher script

Hook (2 minutes). "A locksmith can open a locked door in about thirty seconds. Is that a crime? When is it a crime? When is it a job? ... The skill is the same. What changes? Permission. That's the whole game today: the difference between a burglar and a locksmith is permission, because both can own the same lock picks. Let's learn the Permission Test."

During the lights. "Notice the Yellow zone. Stopping to ask is what professionals do before they touch anything."

On disclosure. "Imagine you're walking by a store and notice the back door is unlocked. Do you go in and look around? No. You find the owner and say, 'Your back door's open.' That's responsible disclosure."

On careers. "Look at the cards. Which job would you want? Notice how many of them are about helping people, writing, teaching, noticing patterns, or fixing things. This field needs lots of kinds of brains. And all of it starts with ethics."

Close. "Curiosity is a gift. Use it where you have permission: your own devices, clubs, practice sites. If you ever find a problem by accident, stop, don't share, and tell a trusted adult. That's the heroic move. And if you've already crossed a line, talk to a trusted adult. It's never too late to do the right thing, and the help is real."

08 Kid-friendly analogies by band

BAND	ANALOGY AND ACTIVITY
K-2	Ask before you use. "It's not mine, so I ask." Practice with classroom items: a friend's backpack, the teacher's computer. "If I find something open that isn't mine, I tell a grown-up."
3-5	The locksmith and the burglar. Both can open doors; only one has permission. Green, Yellow, Red light with 6 simple scenarios.
6-8	The Permission Test, disclosure and careers. Full game; role-play; career gallery.
9-12	Law, ethics, policy and professional paths. CFAA, Van Buren, DOJ policy, safe harbor, bug bounty, CTFs and teams; ethics debate; career pathways and ethics in practice.

09 Discussion questions

1. What is the difference between a locksmith and a burglar? What is the same?
2. Why isn't "I was only curious" enough, and why is "stop and ask" a professional skill?
3. What should a school do when a student reports a security problem? What shouldn't it do?
4. (9-12) Should the law distinguish between harmful intrusions and good-faith research? Where would you draw lines?

10 Level-up challenge

- **Write a Vulnerability Reporting Policy** for a fictional school: how to report, what is in and out of scope, how fast the school responds, and a promise not to punish good-faith reporters who follow the rules [VERIFY with counsel before any real adoption].
- **Join legal practice.** Help start or join a school cyber club or CTF team under teacher supervision, using only learning platforms and isolated labs. A career interview (a visitor or a recorded talk) works well too.
- **Ethics case study (9-12).** Read a well-documented public case of security research that prompted legal threats and discuss what each side could have done differently [VERIFY a suitable public case].

11 Safety and ethics notes (defense only)

- **No attack instruction.** Do not teach or demonstrate how to access, scan, probe or exploit any system. Do not run tools against school or home networks, websites or accounts. Do not recommend any tool for use against a target not provided for practice.
- **No "try it and see".** Do not give any "homework" that involves testing real systems, including students' own accounts on third-party services whose terms forbid it.
- **Be careful with confessions.** A student may confide that they did something unauthorized. Respond calmly: "Thank you for telling me. I'm glad you told me. I need to share this with the right people so we can sort it out and make sure no one is hurt." Do not promise confidentiality; follow the school's policy; do not punish the telling. Involve the counselor and administrator. [VERIFY with administration the policy for student-reported incidents.]
- **Use only legal practice environments** and keep to the program's age rules and terms.

- **Equity.** Cyber clubs and competitions may cost money or require devices; avoid implying that only some students belong. Present multiple paths.
- **Disclosures.** If a student reveals that they are being threatened, coerced into hacking or extorted, or that an adult is directing them to do it, treat it as a safety matter and follow your reporting process (see the Index box).

12 Assessment idea

- **Exit ticket.** "Write the three questions of the Permission Test. Then say what you'd do if you found a hole by accident." Rubric: 3 = permission, scope, purpose/harm and stop-don't-share-tell; 2 = permission and one action; 1 = "I'd look further".
- **Scenario sort.** Four new scenarios; students assign lights with a reason.

13 Sources and [VERIFY] list

- 18 U.S.C. 1030, Computer Fraud and Abuse Act [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: law.cornell.edu].
- Van Buren v. United States, 593 U.S. ____ (2021) [VERIFY citation].
- US Department of Justice, "Policy for Charging Cases under the Computer Fraud and Abuse Act" (May 2022) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: Justice Manual 9-48.000].
- UK Computer Misuse Act 1990 [not re-checked; legislation.gov.uk page was not readable by the checker].
- ISO/IEC 29147 and 30111; RFC 9116 (security.txt) [RFC 9116 VERIFIED 2026-10-05: rfc-editor.org; ISO page not readable by the checker].
- CERT/CC and CISA coordinated vulnerability disclosure guidance [VERIFY].
- ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct (2018) [VERIFY].
- NIST SP 800-181 (NICE Framework) [NICE Framework Resource Center page exists: VERIFIED 2026-10-05: nist.gov; use the current version].
- US Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Outlook, Information Security Analysts [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: bls.gov].
- (ISC)2 Cybersecurity Workforce Study; CyberSeek [VERIFY].
- CyberPatriot (Air and Space Forces Association), picoCTF (Carnegie Mellon) as examples of legal practice environments [existence and basics VERIFIED 2026-10-05; check current age and access rules before each season].

Student Handout: The Permission Test

Name: _____

The big idea

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A defender and a lawbreaker is **permission, scope and purpose**, not skill.

The Permission Test (ask before touching any system that isn't yours)

1. **Permission:** do I have clear permission from the owner?
2. **Scope:** am I staying inside what they allowed?
3. **Purpose and harm:** is my aim to help, and am I avoiding harm?

IF ANY ANSWER IS "no" or "not sure": stop and ask a trusted adult.

Green, Yellow, Red

Write G, Y or R:

1. A school hires a company with a signed agreement to test only its own systems. ____
2. A friend dares you to guess a classmate's password. ____
3. You solve a challenge on a practice website made for learners. ____
4. You accidentally see another student's information on a school site. ____
5. You tell a business: "Pay me or I'll publish your flaw." ____

If I find a hole by accident

1. **Stop.** Don't poke around.
2. **Don't share** or save anything.
3. **Tell** a trusted adult or the school's IT.

Careers are a lot of different jobs

CIRCLE TWO THAT INTEREST you: analyst / incident responder / ethical hacker / forensic examiner / cryptographer / privacy professional / teacher / IT support / policy and law

One skill I already have: _____

One skill I want to build: _____

Where can I practice legally?

ASK YOUR TEACHER ABOUT school clubs, practice websites made for learning, and competitions with rules. Never test real systems that aren't yours.

Remember

- Curiosity is great. Use it where you have permission.
- "It was easy" and "I only looked" are not permission.
- If you ever crossed a line, talk to a trusted adult. It's never too late to do the right thing.

End of student handout.

TEACHER COPY ONLY:

Answers for Demo 14 (do not distribute to students)

FIELD NOTE

No. 1

WARNING: Teacher page. Remove before copying. The student handout ends on the page before this one. Print the handout pages only, or detach this page first. Do not post it, project it or send it home.

Green, Yellow, Red (handout): 1 G (signed agreement, in scope); 2 R (no permission, harms a person's privacy); 3 G (a target provided for practice); 4 Y (stop, do not explore, tell a trusted adult or IT); 5 R (extortion).

Career and practice questions: no single right answer; praise students who name a skill they already have. Most roles on the career cards involve no breaking into anything.

Reminders for the guided discussion:

- "Yellow" is a skill: stop and ask is the professional's superpower.
- A gray hat can still be prosecuted; good intentions do not create permission.
- Students never report vulnerabilities on their own: they go through a trusted adult.
- A student who confesses something already done gets thanks first, then the school's process. Do not promise confidentiality, and do not punish the telling [VERIFY the policy with administration].